But what does it mean to me to be a practising Hindu? As I mentioned above, I have never been a frequent visitor to temples, though I do believe in praying every day, even if only for a couple of minutes. Many Hindus who can afford the space have a place for puja within their homes; at minimum, a picture, a little statue, or several. I too have maintained a little puja alcove at my homes where I try to reach out to the divine spirit. Yet, I believe in the Upanishadic doctrine that the Divine is essentially unknowable and unattainable by ordinary mortals. All prayer is an attempt to reach out to that which we cannot touch. While I do occasionally visit temples, and I appreciate how important they are to my mother and most other devout Hindus, I believe that one does not need any intermediaries between oneself and one's notion of the Divine. If God is in your heart, it matters little where else He resides.

So I take pride in the openness, the diversity, the range, the sublime philosophical aspirations of the Vedanta. I cherish the diversity, the lack of compulsion, and the richness of the various ways in which Hinduism is practised eclectically. And I admire the civilisational heritage of tolerance that makes Hindu societies open their arms to people of every other faith, to come and practise their beliefs in peace amidst Hindus. It is remarkable, for instance, that the only country on earth where the Jewish people have lived for centuries and never experienced a single episode of anti-Semitism is India. That is the Hinduism in which I gladly take pride.

Hinduism's suitability for the modern world lies in many ways in its recognition of uncertainty and its pragmatic non-dogmatism. The religion of 'maybe He does not know' is a faith for the non-dogmatic, one which looks beyond the blacks and whites, the grim certitudes of lesser mortals, to the acknowledgement of the scope for doubt, for different points of view on the great questions of life and death. Vivekananda's immortal 'We believe not only in universal toleration but we accept all religions as true' is a prescription for peace and coexistence among competing dogmatisms in a world full of too many dogmas. This is why it was perhaps the ideal faith for a candidate for United Nations Secretary General to profess. (And when I lost the race, my faith offered